Act of Devotion

By Deborah Tannen

FATHER: a man of eighty-five
DAUGHTER: a woman in her late forties

INTRODUCTION

When speaking about the Holocaust, author Jane Yolen once said "Fiction cannot recite the numbing numbers, but it can be that witness, that memory. A storyteller can attempt to tell the human tale, can make a galaxy out of the chaos, can point to the fact that some people survived even as most people died. And can remind us that the swallows still sing around the smokestacks." How the Holocaust impacted the future generations of Jewish families is a topic not often addressed, but in Act of Devotion by Deborah Tannen, we find a daughter traveling back to Warsaw with her Jewish family – a family that survived and love of a father figure shines through the tears. Act of Devotion by Deborah Tannen.

A hotel room in Warsaw in August, late afternoon. FATHER speaks in the voice of his memory, a younger version of himself. The tone of both DAUGHTER's and FATHER's dialogue is understatement and subtle irony, not stereotypically or exaggeratedly Jewish cadences}.

DAUGHTER: The first thing we did after checking into our hotel in Warsaw was to take a taxi to where my father had lived as a child. The street was still there, with its street sign, Twarda *[Pronounced "tuarda"],* but in place of the apartment house he had lived in was a grim gray building with a cement wall covered with obscene spray-painted graffiti - I was overwhelmed with the thought that I was standing on the street I had heard my father talk about all my life.

FATHER: We stood under the sign, Twarda Ulica *[pronounced "tuarda ooleetsa"].* How dull and quiet it was, how faceless and bland the buildings that had been put up since the war. When I was a child, the neighborhood was always in commotion and crowded with life. Both sides of the street were lined with stores, and the sidewalks were teeming with people - Hasidim with their long beards,

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black boots, and the ritual fringes of their prayer shawls peeking out from under their vests. Working men, women shopping, men going to and from the synagogue. There were "tragers" - carriers - men hired by people too poor to hire a wagon, carrying amazing loads on their backs - a desk, a bed. Epileptics would fall down and have convulsions in the street. No one stopped to watch, because it was common. And beggars, everywhere beggars in torn clothes. Some wore garments sewn from sacks, some had rags on their feet instead of shoes. Many of the beggars were cripples. When I came to America, I always wondered: where were the cripples?

DAUGHTER: On the second day, we went to the National History museum where we'd heard there was a film about the destruction of Warsaw during World War II. The narrator told how the inhabitants of the city were deported to another part of the country as the Germans systematically demolished their city. When the war ended, the city's inhabitants returned. There was inspiring documentary footage of the Poles handing stones from man to man as they rebuilt Warsaw - but nothing about the killing of thirty percent of the population of the city - the entire Jewish population. There were a few fleeting shots of Jews being deported, as the narrator's voice said, "The Jews were the first to go." He neglected to mention that they didn't come back.

FATHER: In the street were droshkis *[pronounced "DROSHkeez'j* - horsedrawn carriages that took passengers, and open wagons for trade. The drivers were beating and yelling at their horses, and yelling at pedestrians to get out of the way. Occasionally a "kareta" drove by - a fancy carriage that rich people rode in. One day an old Hasid stepped off the curb just as an automobile came rushing into the space between the streetcar and the curb, and its wheel ran over the old man's foot. As the man shrieked in pain, the driver

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stopped his car, got out, rushed over to the old man, and began loudly berating him for getting in his way. Soon after I arrived in America, I saw a cab driver and his passenger standing by the cab, arguing with each other. I couldn't get over the contrast. In Poland, if you were rich enough to drive an automobile, you had the right to yell at anyone. In America, a cab driver, in his worker's cap, was shouting at a rich man in a silk top hat.

DAUGHTER: We went to the Jewish cemetery where my father's grandmother was buried. He told us about attending her funeral when he was eleven, shortly before he left for America. He said his grandmother's funeral was so vivid in his mind, he felt as if he could walk right to her grave, but he couldn't walk to it, because the cemetery he'd visited as a child had been destroyed during the war. Headstones had been smashed by vandals or uprooted by trees that sprouted up; paths had been obliterated by undergrowth.

FATHER: Our apartment building was built around a cobblestone courtyard. You entered through a huge archway with wooden doors that were locked at night. There were storefronts facing the courtyard, at ground level. During the day vendors came in, shouting about what they had to sell. Beggars came in and went from door to door, asking for a kopek or a piece of bread, which they'd put into a sack.

DAUGHTER: We went to the memorial to the Warsaw ghetto uprising. There's a long approach to the monument, leading up to a dynamic statue hurtling out of a stone wall: muscular young men brandishing arms, who chose to die fighting rather than follow orders for deportation. On another day, a Polish woman, took us back to see the other side of the monument: a frieze of a throng of people streaming to their deaths - a rabbi carrying a torah, families with children dwarfed by the legs around them. This, she told us, was the truer representation. There were sixty thousand people left in the ghetto at the

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time of the uprising. Three hundred thousand of the ghetto's inhabitants had been killed in Treblinka in the months before. We had missed this part of the monument on our first visit. We hadn't thought to walk around and look at the back.

FATHER: Vendors came into the courtyard, shouting about what they had to sell. One man had a grinding wheel; people brought him knives and scissors to sharpen. Another man would push a wheelbarrow into the courtyard and set up shop. He took iron pots blackened from cooking and returned them sparkling and shiny.

DAUGHTER: At the ghetto monument, my father got into a conversation with a young Danish woman holding a guidebook. As he walked away, I told her that he had grown up in Warsaw, that his grandfather had died in the ghetto, and that other family members and people he'd grown up with had died there, or lived there and died in the camps. I brandished this information as a badge of honor, as if it gave me a greater right to be visiting the memorial.

FATHER: Our third-floor apartment was my grandfather's home. I was born there, and so was my mother. I lived there until I was seven. My mother was one of the oldest of sixteen brothers and sisters. The youngest was only six years older than I, so I was like the youngest brother, and my grandfather was the closest I ever came to having a father. For years I thought my grandfather's name was "zahzogit" because that's what my grandmother called him: "Zahzogit, would you pull out that chair?", "Zahzogit, may I have money to shop for food?" Then I found out that "zahzogit" meant "be so good." When she spoke to him, she began that way to be properly deferential to her husband. His children feared him, because he was stern and author-itarian with them, but he was always kind and gentle to me.

DAUGHTER: When I was seven or eight, I wrote my first story. It was about my father

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when he was a child. The story took place in the stairwell outside his apartment in Warsaw. It was a story he'd told me: when he was very little, his mother dressed him in his older sister's outgrown dresses, rather than spend money buying boy's clothes for him. He was too ashamed to go out and play dressed as a girl, so he sat in the stairwell all day and cried.

FATHER: My mother was married at eighteen to a man she'd never met, and she never liked him. She threw him out when I was two. She never told me directly that I was ugly, but whenever she spoke of my father, she's say how she hated his looks, especially his long hooked nose. And whenever she spoke about me, she'd say I looked exactly like him. When I did something she didn't like, which was just about anything I ever did, she'd say, "Just like your father." It wasn't until I was an adult and talked to people who knew him that I found out my father had been a wonderful man. They said he was kind, gentle, intelligent, and generous. Everyone loved him, except my mother.

DAUGHTER: My father talked so much about his childhood that I felt it as if it had happened to me. But it hadn't happened to me. I believed that nothing that happened to me could be as significant as what he had suffered. What right did I have to be miserable. In my memory, my childhood is an endless train of days spent with my mother, missing my father. He left the house before I woke up in the morning, and he often worked late, so he came home after I had gone to sleep. My favorite object in the house was an old black typewriter with yellow keys rimmed in silver. I'd spend hours typing letters to my father, telling him what had happened to me during the day and laying out my grievances against my mother. I couldn't have any grievances against him, because he wasn't there.

FATHER: My father had tuberculosis. My mother told people that was why she threw

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him out - so he wouldn't infect my sister and me. And she said she never remarried because she didn't want her children to grow up with a stepfather. Maybe it was true. But I always believed she preferred to live on her own. She wasn't the kind of woman who wanted to spend her life waiting on a man.

DAUGHTER: Sometimes when he was home at our bedtime, my father told us stories that he made up himself -long elaborate tales of dragons and eagles in which we were the heroes. As we lay in our beds, he'd move around the room, acting out all the parts, suddenly rushing right up to our delighted, mock-scared, laughing faces. And then, when it was time to sleep, he'd lie down with us, and we'd snuggle up to him with our heads on his shoulder. That way I could always fall asleep . . . When I was a teenager, I prided myself on my irreverence. I liked to shock people by saying, "If my father had stayed in Poland, he'd be a lamp shade."

FATHER: When I was six, my father died. He was twenty-seven years old. Since I didn't know him, I wasn't sad; I thought it was an interesting piece of news. When I ran into a neighbor on the staircase, I boasted excitedly that I knew something she didn't. "What is it?" she asked. "That your father died?" Though I never knew my father, I certainly knew my grandfather. There was no question in my mind that he was the most powerful, most dignified man in the world, and I was sure everyone else knew this too. But one day, after World War I finally ended, he took me with him on an expedition to the home of someone who owed him money. I was shocked to see the manner he assumed in this house, as he doffed his cap in deference. I couldn't believe my eyes: my grandfather, taking his hat off to someone!

DAUGHTER: Years ago I had a dream. I'm having a birthday party. My father is there, but he's suspended about two feet off the ground, with his head near the

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ceiling. I don't know what he's doing up there; he doesn't seem to be doing anything, just floating in his own world. I can't reach him, and he doesn't hear me or see me. I desperately try to make contact with him, but he's stuck up there and I can't get him to come down.

FATHER: When we were about to leave for America, my grandfather called me to him and took me on his lap. Tears streamed from beneath his gold-rimmed glasses, down his cheeks, and into his beard. He knew he would never see me again. With his arm around my shoulders, he said, "Never forget that you are a Jew."

DAUGHTER: I'd always known that my father's grandfather died in the Warsaw ghetto, but somehow I'd assumed he died of old age, and the ghetto happened to be where he lived when his time came. In my mind, "the ghetto" was just a dilapidated section of town where Jews were forced to live. But one day, I realized how much I didn't know - that Jews had been crammed into the ghetto from all over the city and the country; that 1 00,000 people died there from starvation, and from epidemics that broke out, caused by the overcrowding and unsanitary conditions. Naked corpses lay in the streets - corpses in the street because people had to pay a fee to bury their dead and they had no money; naked because every shred of cloth had to be salvaged and used. Women nursed infants in the street, but they had no breasts, no nourishment to give their dying babies. German soldiers strolled through the ghetto on their way to somewhere else and shot people for fun. I thought I knew about the Warsaw ghetto, but I really didn't know anything about it at all.

FATHER: Those were my grandfather's last words to me: "Never forget you are a Jew." He believed that when Jews went to America, they ceased to be Jews, because they stopped being Hasidic. Have I betrayed him? What do my

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daughters know of their Jewish heritage? What can being Jewish mean to them, having grown up in America? Only one of them married a Jew - and she doesn't have children, so what difference does it make?

DAUGHTER: We went to the Unschlagplatz, where each day thousands ofJews gathered to be shipped to Treblinka, where they'd be gassed. Today it's a green park with a monument, a series of stone walls. One wall is a glittering white stone slab with Jewish names, meant to represent the three hundred thousand people who had been sent to be killed from this square. Mordechai, Moishe, Shmuel, Abraham, Rachel, Rebecca, Naomi, Leah, Sarah, Miriam, Deborah. Another stone slab bore the words of a poem. We all lined up facing this wall, and asked my father to translate the Polish text etched into the stone. *[As she speaks these lines,* DAUGHTER *walks over to* FATHER *and stands beside him on his left, as they both enact the scene she describes.]* He began to read the words, but his voice faltered, and he stopped. I turned to see that his body was shaking. He put his right hand up to his left cheek, palm out, making a barrier between our eyes, so I couldn't see his face as he sobbed. I put my arm around him. He gathered himself up and started to read again. But again, he stopped. Again, he held his hand to the side of his face, like a shield against my gaze. On the third try he read:

FATHER: "Earth, do not cover my blood; wind, do not silence my screams ... "

DAUGHTER: As we walked away, my mother whispered to me that in the sixty years of their marriage, she had never seen him break down before. Days later, he told us what overcame him was a picture in his mind of his grandfather and his uncle Joshua, the only son who had stayed behind with the old man, and Joshua's wife and five children. They had all almost certainly been shipped to their deaths from the spot on which we stood. And he kept thinking, "What had they done to deserve their fate? They had never done anything

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to hurt anyone."

FATHER: I stood under the street sign, Twarda Ulica. Inside my head, it was all still there: the busy courtyards, the people calling out of the windows, the streetcars clanging, the drivers yelling, my grandfather going to shul, But outside, there was nothing. No trace of the world I grew up in. In place of the three-story apartment house with its courtyard was a gray utilitarian building covered with obscene graffiti. After I'm gone, who will remember? If no one remembers, what will remain?

DAUGHTER: My father wanted to take pictures of the Jewish cemetery, but he hates to waste pictures with no one in them, but I hung back. I couldn't figure out if it was a desecration to pose for pictures, like tourists, in a place like that, or if it was an act of devotion, to try to remember.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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